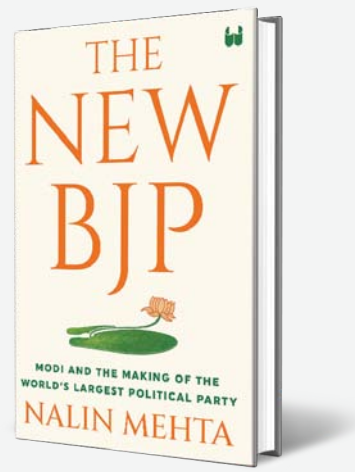
a linear history of the party's transformation over 70 years. It grapples with the difficulties posed by the sudden demise of the Jan Sangh's first president Syama Prasad Mookerjee to the dilemmas the party faced after walking out of the Janata Party. Further chapters deal with the party's expanding base in the aftermath of the *mandir* mobilisation, its first tryst with power at the national level, and the party's unexpected defeat in 2004. Chapters seven through nine discuss the period between 2004 and 2014, and the final chapters focus on the party's geographical and social expansion since then and the 2019 campaign.

The book is replete with telling anecdotes. One describes how a day before the 2004 election results, Pramod Mahajan tried to make a case before the then PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee that the BJP was likely to win more seats than in 1999. Vajpayee smiled and said, pack your bags and get ready to sit in the Opposition. Only party insiders could be privy to such information and it is a welcome initiative that an active politician is writing about the party's journey. Similarly, the analysis of the economic policies of the Vajpayee and Modi governments brings Patnaik's voice to the fore. The book also lists ways in which the BJP remains in action on the ground and mobilises its constituencies through *yatras*, *divases* and *samvaads*.

While it was expected that a practitioner's perspective will be sympathetic, this is a lost opportunity to record more details of how the BJP functions. One hoped for a more analytical insight on the loss of 2004, the churn within the party in its aftermath, and on its changing relationship with the RSS over the past 20 years. Similarly, the discussion on ideology focuses on what is socially desirable rather than analysing how the BJP differentiates itself from other parties.

Mehta, on the other hand, submerges himself into microscopic details in search for explanations for the scale of the BJP's victories, particularly since Modi's rise to power. His account of the BJP focuses on the past decade and seamlessly blends a variety of methodological techniques.

The thematic organisation of the book answers the question that Mehta poses in five parts. In part one, the focus is on the accommodation of backward castes through the nomination of candidates and appointments in the party organisation as well as the cabinet, and reaching out to poor and interior areas through welfare and infrastructure. Part two analyses the party's use of digital technology in comparison to the Congress, how its communication strategy and organisational restructuring have helped it to become a gigantic election machine. Part three discusses the evolution of the party's economic thinking from the Jan Sangh days to Modi's model of welfarism. Part four focuses on the umbilical cord between the RSS and the BJP. It also marshals data to show the increasing footprint of the RSS in various parts of the country. Part five relies on case studies to document the BJP's geographical expansion in India's southern and eastern states and the strategies that have driven it.



▲ **THE NEW BJP**
Modi and the Making of the World's Largest Political Party
By Nalin Mehta
WESTLAND
₹751; 840 pages

Mehta and his collaborators have assembled a variety of new data for this volume—for example, an original digital database of 11,588 BJP-linked documents between 2006 and 2019. This offline literature was then compared with the social media posts by the top BJP leadership using data-mining software NARAD (Normative Analysis of Reporting and Discourse), developed specifically for this project, to show how communication patterns change over time.

While I may have some quibbles over the interpretation of a few data points, the rich set of new materials Mehta has collected is truly impressive. The book, however, falls short of expectations in presenting a theoretically more robust explanation and engaging narrative of the BJP's rise given the wealth of information at the author's disposal. Nor does he make an attempt to grapple with why the BJP still finds it difficult to strengthen its position in states like Tamil Nadu and Kerala despite the resources at its command.

The party's massive victory in the 2019 election confirmed the rise of the second dominant party system with the BJP as the system-defining party. While the party continues to face electoral challenges in the states and push-back by civil society groups on various issues, it has moved swiftly, creating one wedge after the other. And this has kept the parliamentary opposition in a state of suspended animation. Along with this a great game has begun to dislodge the Congress as the main opposition with the Trinamool Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party jostling for the second spot, increasing the electoral distance between the BJP and the rest in a fragmented political space. These developments, along with the machinery that the BJP has created in the past decade (described in these two books) gives the party a far-reaching advantage over its competitors. Can this machine withstand the increasing concerns over the economy, religious tensions and demands of various pressure groups? The election results on March 10 will give us the first indication. ■

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